

Yemen and the Houthis

Civil War, Red Sea Campaign, and the Iran-Backed Threat to Global Shipping

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Executive Summary

Yemen's civil war has undergone a strategic metamorphosis since late 2023. The Houthi movement (Ansar Allah), having consolidated administrative control over northern Yemen including all northern ports, launched a maritime campaign in the Red Sea framed as solidarity with Gaza. That campaign sharply reduced the numbers of vessels using the Red Sea corridor FT[2025-07-29]. The humanitarian toll remains severe: UN officials describe Yemen as facing a "severe and worsening humanitarian crisis," with an estimated 19.5 million people requiring humanitarian assistance as of early 2025 [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — CRS: Yemen: Terrorism Designation, U.S. Policy, and Congress (2025-03-13)].

In January 2025, the Houthis halted their attacks against ships associated with the United States and the United Kingdom following the start of the Israeli-Palestinian ceasefire [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — CRS: Yemen: Terrorism Designation, U.S. Policy, and Congress (2025-03-13)]. Israeli officials stated they would continue to act against the Houthis in response to attacks on Israel and threatened to target Houthi leadership [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — CRS: Yemen: Terrorism Designation, U.S. Policy, and Congress (2025-03-13)]. As of August 2026, the UN's Yemen Special Envoy warned that "the fear of a return to full conflict is palpable" [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — CRS: Yemen: Terrorism Designation, U.S. Policy, and Congress (2025-03-13)].

Part I — The Conflict's Current Trajectory

The Houthi movement controls all northern ports in Yemen, through which most humanitarian relief items enter the country [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — CRS: Yemen: Terrorism Designation, U.S. Policy, and Congress (2025-03-13)]. In August 2026, Houthi forces struck Marib again; Yemen's army stated it had responded against Houthi forces on several fronts along the lines of contact and would respond to any further targeting of its units with "necessary military measures" CNA[2026-08-08]. A displaced persons camp on the outskirts of the contested Marib area sustained damage in the August 2026 strikes CNA[2026-08-08].

The United States redesignated the Houthis as a terrorist organisation, an action that UN and humanitarian officials warned could affect commercial trade and humanitarian operations in Yemen, with lasting impacts on its population [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — CRS: Yemen: Terrorism Designation, U.S. Policy, and Congress (2025-03-13)].

Regional adaptation to Yemen's persistent instability has taken a particular form: rather than resolving the underlying conflict, neighbouring states and trade partners have progressively worked around it. As one Financial Times analysis framed it, "the region is adapting by designing Yemen out of its future"

Part II — Humanitarian Conditions

The conflict and the associated Red Sea crisis together contribute to what UN officials describe as a severe and worsening humanitarian crisis. As of early 2025, an estimated 19.5 million people in Yemen required humanitarian assistance [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — CRS: Yemen: Terrorism Designation, U.S. Policy, and Congress (2025-03-13)]. Terrorism designations, US assistance policy changes, or escalation of conflict could affect humanitarian operations, with UN Security Council-backed arrangements dependent on Houthi cooperation at northern ports through which most relief supplies enter the country [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — CRS: Yemen: Terrorism Designation, U.S. Policy, and Congress (2025-03-13)].

Part III — The Red Sea Campaign

Houthi attacks sharply reduced the numbers of vessels using the Red Sea FT[2025-07-29]. The Houthis publicly stated they would step up attacks on vessels using the Red Sea, citing the situation in Gaza as justification FT[2025-07-29]. Their targeting decisions have at times been questioned even within the logic of their stated criteria: reporting noted that "in the past, they've attacked ships" on the basis of "outdated information," raising the risk profile for all commercial shipping in the corridor FT[2025-07-29].

The Houthi maritime capability constitutes what naval analysts have termed a Littoral Strike Complex (LSC): an integrated combination of sensors, command-and-control nodes, and a mix of effectors including missiles and drones that produced "deadly consequences for merchant vessels on both sides of the Bab el Mandeb" [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — NWC Review: Narrowing Seas—The Littoral Strike Complex and the Future of Naval Warfare (Summer 2026)]. Russia and China have similarly facilitated Houthi LSC capabilities; Moscow joined the effort by supplying arms [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — NWC Review: Summer 2026 Full Issue (Summer 2026)].

Israel launched multiple strikes on Yemen. Israeli officials stated they will continue to act against the Houthis in response to attacks on Israel FT[2025-01-14] [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — CRS: Yemen: Terrorism Designation, U.S. Policy, and Congress (2025-03-13)].

In January 2025, the Houthis halted attacks against ships associated with the United States and the United Kingdom following the start of the Israeli-Palestinian ceasefire [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — CRS: Yemen: Terrorism Designation, U.S. Policy, and Congress (2025-03-13)].

Part IV — External Enablement of Houthi Capability

The Houthi military capability reflects external investment over many years. Iran's support for Houthi air defences in Yemen has been documented in open-source and official analysis [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — NWC Review: Summer 2026 Full Issue (Summer 2026)]. The NWC Review (Summer 2026) identifies Russia and China as having similarly facilitated the Houthis' LSC capabilities, with Moscow supplying arms to undermine Western interests [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — NWC Review: Summer 2026 Full Issue (Summer 2026)].

The conduct of the Saudi-led coalition has also attracted scrutiny. Reporting documented that at least 40 per cent of soldiers fighting for the Saudi-led coalition were children, and that in June 2019, then-US Secretary of State Mike Pompeo blocked the inclusion of Saudi Arabia on the US list of countries that recruit child soldiers, dismissing his own experts' findings [RAG: CONFLICT_RAG — Yemen civil war (undated)].

Conclusion

Yemen's conflict remains active and unresolved as of August 2026, with Houthi forces continuing to strike contested territories including Marib CNA[2026-08-08] while controlling the northern ports through which humanitarian relief enters the country [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — CRS: Yemen: Terrorism Designation, U.S. Policy, and Congress (2025-03-13)]. An estimated 19.5 million Yemenis require humanitarian assistance [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — CRS: Yemen: Terrorism Designation, U.S. Policy, and Congress (2025-03-13)]. The Houthi maritime campaign succeeded in sharply reducing Red Sea shipping traffic FT[2025-07-29], a capability built on an integrated Littoral Strike Complex enabled by Iran, Russia, and China [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — NWC Review: Summer 2026 Full Issue (Summer 2026)]. The UN's Yemen Special Envoy has warned that the fear of a return to full conflict is palpable, and the broader regional response has been to adapt by designing Yemen out of its strategic future rather than resolving the underlying war [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — CRS: Yemen: Terrorism Designation, U.S. Policy, and Congress (2025-03-13)] FT[2026-06-11].

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